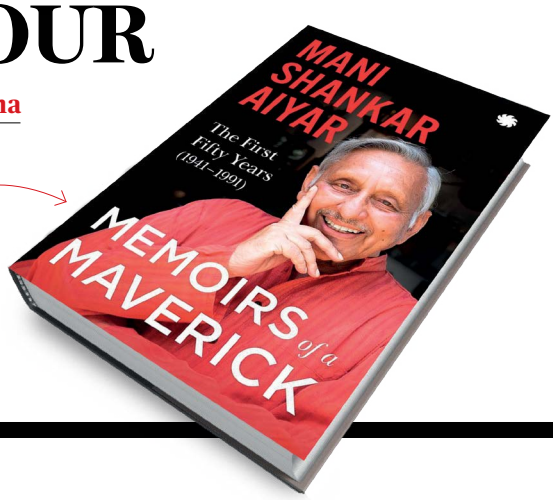
BOOKS

DIPLOMACY WITH A SENSE OF HUMOUR

By Prem Shankar Jha



MEMOIRS OF A MAVERICK
The First Fifty Years (1941-1991)
By Mani Shankar Aiyar
JUGGERNAUT
₹899; 379 pages

Mani Shankar Aiyar's *Memoirs of a Maverick* is the first of three books on his life that are slated to be published by Juggernaut in the coming months. Anyone who takes a hasty look at his bio-data—born in a well-to-do Brahmin family; educated at the Doon School, St Stephen's College and Trinity Hall, Cambridge; inducted straight from university into the Indian Foreign Service, and from there into the Congress party—would conclude unhesitatingly that he has lived a privileged life.

Some of them might then wonder where he got his occasionally abrasive toughness from. The answer is that Mani Shankar Aiyar did come from a gifted family, but it was gifted only in intellect. For the rest, he and his brother Swaminathan had to fight every inch of the way. Mani's first battle was with the trauma of his father's death in an air crash. Only those who have lost a loved one in a similar sudden and terrifying way can appreciate what he must have gone through. His father's foresight in taking out a life insurance policy earlier saved the family from penury. But at Doon, Mani had to deal with being one of the very, very few students (mostly children of the schoolmasters) who were day scholars in a school where almost everyone else was a boarder. As a result, he was at the receiving end of some faint condescension. Mani and Swaminathan took their 'revenge' by topping classes and winning a plethora of debating and essay prizes.

His entry into the IFS was even more traumatic. After having come seventh in the All-India Combined Services examination, he found himself being refused entry into the Indian Administrative Service (IAS) and the IFS because a police report had tagged him as having become a member of the British Communist Party. For the Indian police, this was taboo. Only the intervention of Dr S. Radhakrishnan and Jawaharlal Nehru himself, on the advice of senior government officials, got Mani Shankar into the IFS. That happened after months of trauma and despair.

Mani's description of his early years in the service, after two hilariously uneducative years at the Mussoorie academy, are not remarkable but well worth reading for the self-deprecating humour with which he writes about himself, his colleagues and the tedium of life in the IFS. However, this changes in the chapter about his posting as Consul-General in Karachi, where he re-opened the Indian Consulate in December 1978. That deeply felt chapter describes the longing to reconnect with India that he found in Karachi and pretty much all of Sindh, even 31 years after Partition. What I found most worthy of note was that the Pakistanis he quotes—from visa applicants to former PMs—opened their hearts to him because they sensed in him neither prejudice nor hostility but open-minded curiosity not unmixed with warmth. At a certain point, he asks whether this is not the ingredient that diplomacy often lacks but most desperately needs. After reading this chapter, it's impossible to disagree with him.

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The Pakistan chapter is only exceeded in length by the chapter on his time with Rajiv Gandhi. This otherwise fascinating but poignant chapter is the only one in which I find myself in disagreement with Mani's political analysis. He correctly points out that the three domestic crises that ended the Congress's 42-year dominance were the reversal of the Shah Bano judgment, the breaking of the locks on the Babri Masjid, and the Bofors scandal in which, as we now more or less know, it was Arun Nehru who was the chief culprit though Rajiv got the blame.

At the time of Bofors, I was the editor of the *Hindustan Times* and had categorically rejected the accusations being hurled by the Opposition against Rajiv and the Gandhi family, for the utter lack of evidence. But I cannot absolve Rajiv of blame of allowing himself to be persuaded to overturn the Supreme Court's judgment on the Shah Bano case, and allowing Arun Nehru to persuade him to open the Babri Masjid in order to propitiate some imagined Hindu sentiment and win a few votes. He was, after all, the prime minister of India. So, the buck had to stop with him. ■

Prem Shankar Jha *is an economist, journalist and author*